

Working Effectively in Schools

Education Assistance Diploma Program
School District 41
Burnaby, B.C

August 24th – 28th, 2026
Instructor: Heather Wall (she/her)

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We acknowledge and thank the Coast Salish Nations of Musqueam, Tsleil-Waututh and Squamish on whose traditional territories we teach, learn and live.



Aboriginal Education in Burnaby Schools

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Unit 1 - Overview

- Course Guidelines and Outline
- Introductions
- Personal Beliefs and Biases
- Verbal and Non-verbal Communication
- Communication Styles
- Learning and Personality Styles
- Executive Functions
- Fixed Vs Growth Mindset

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Introductions

Instructor

Participants

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Participant Introductions:

- Name
- What led you on this journey to become an educational assistant?

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Course Guidelines



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Course Outline:

- Unit 1 – Verbal and Nonverbal Communication – Communication, Learning and Personality Styles
- Unit 2 –Working Effectively with Teams - Managing Conflict
- Unit 3 –Emergency Preparedness, Burnaby Schools Communicable Disease Safety - Employee Assistance Program – Burnaby Beliefs and Values – Safe and Caring Schools – School Structures
- Unit 4 –Professionalism/Roles and Responsibilities

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Assignments/Evaluation

- Class participation & Attendance/Punctuality 20%
 - Small group discussion
 - Large group discussion
 - Homework
 - Being on time – start of day and after breaks
- Exit Slips 5%
- Growth Mindset Assignment 10%
- Difficult People Assignment 10%
- Response Script Writing Assignment 15%
- Developing Student Independence Assignment 10%
- Group Activity: Using an IEP for Lunchtime Activities 10%
- Quiz 20%

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Four Agreements

1. Be Impeccable with your Word:

Speak with integrity. Say only what you mean. Avoid using the Word to speak against yourself or to gossip about others. Use the power of your Word in the direction of truth and love.

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Four Agreements

2. Don't Take Anything Personally

Nothing others do is because of you. What others say and do is a projection of their own reality, their own dream. When you are immune to the opinions and actions of others, you won't be the victim of needless suffering.

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Four Agreements

3. Don't Make Assumptions

Find the courage to ask questions and to express what you really want. Communicate with others as clearly as you can to avoid misunderstandings, sadness and drama. With just this one agreement, you can completely transform your life.

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Four Agreements

4. Always Do Your Best

Your best is going to change from moment to moment; it will be different when you are healthy as opposed to sick. Under any circumstance, simply do your best and you will avoid self-judgment, self-abuse, and regret.

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Fifth Agreement

5. Be skeptical, but learn to listen

Be skeptical because most of what you hear isn't true.

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Four Agreements

Discussion:

Simple is not always easy:

Which of these agreements speaks most loudly to you and what difference would it make if you took this on?

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Personal Beliefs and Biases

- Values
- Beliefs
- Attitudes

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Values

Principles, standards or qualities that an individual or group of people hold in high regard. Values guide how to act in various situations and help to decide what is right and wrong.

Examples:

- Inclusion
- Professionalism
- Behaviour
- Education
- The Environment
- Honesty

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Clarifying your values

- What values are important to you? Honesty? Compassion? Friendship? Success?
- How are these values expressed in your life?
- Are any of your values in conflict with how you behave?
- Are any of your values in conflict with your job, friendships, or relationships?

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Burnaby's Values

- **Students First**
- **Joy and Curiosity**
- **Truth and Reconciliation**
- **Belonging**
- **Collaboration**

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What is a belief?

- A belief is best defined as an attitude about the world that is considered to be true, but not all our beliefs are true.
- In other words, when you believe something to be true you will rarely question or think about the validity of that belief.
- You form your beliefs from a very early age. These beliefs are based on your environment; what you were told, what you heard as well as what you observed and experienced. Your beliefs are also the conclusions you draw from these experiences. You form beliefs about yourself, about others and the world around you.

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Beliefs

Caution - beliefs can be related to stereotypes that have developed over the years and may impact the way we relate to colleagues, students, parents and others.

Beliefs come from real experiences, but we often forget that the original experience is not the same as what is happening now.

Examples:

- All children need discipline and consequences
- Children are affected by family values
- Some children will never learn
- Not all students should be in the classroom
- Girls are more social than boys

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Re-examine your limiting and negatives beliefs and ask yourself:

- Where does this belief come from?
- Is this my belief or have I adopted it from someone else?
- How does this belief help me?
- How does this belief hinder me?
- How do I know this belief is true?
- What is my new and updated belief?

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WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN BELIEFS AND VALUES?	
BELIEFS	VALUES
Beliefs don't need proof	Values stem from our beliefs
Beliefs are assumptions we make about others and ourselves	Values govern the way we behave and interact with others
Beliefs grow from what we experience and think about	Values are things we deem important
Beliefs affect our morals	Values affect behaviour and character

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Attitude

Attitudes are feelings learned over time that cause us to act, think, and feel a certain way about events or other people. *Attitudes* generally inform how we treat other people and react to situations in our lives.

Examples of attitudes:

- Girls are well behaved; boys like to fool around.
- I am just an EA – no one wants to hear what I think.
- Parents don't know what school is like.
- They would do well if they just tried harder.
- Teenagers have no respect.

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Values, Beliefs and Attitudes

A belief is an internal feeling that something is true, even though that belief may be unproven or irrational

I believe that there is life after death.

A value is a measure of the worth or importance a person attaches to something; our values are often reflected in the way we live our lives.

I value freedom of speech, or I value my family.

An attitude is the way a person expresses or applies their beliefs and values, and is expressed through words and behaviour.

I hate school.

Pratima Nayak, KV/FW

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Common Challenging Behaviours → What's Really Happening?	
BEHAVIOUR	MAY LOOK LIKE
Non compliance	- willful misconduct - Attention seeking - stubbornness
Repetition of mistakes	- willful misconduct - being manipulative
Failure to sit still	- attention seeking - interference with others - willful misconduct
Failure to work independently	- willful misconduct - poor parenting
Failure to complete homework	- irresponsibility - laziness - unsupportive parenting
Lack of punctuality	- laziness, dawdling - poor parenting - willful misconduct
Poor social judgment	- poor parenting - willful misconduct - effects of child abuse
Physical intrusiveness	- willful misconduct - deviancy
Stealing	- deliberate dishonesty - lack of conscience
Lying	- deliberate lying - sociopathic behavior - lack of conscience
	MAY BE - difficulty translating verbal directions into action - difficulty understanding - difficulty linking cause to effect - difficulty seeing similarities - difficulty generalizing - neurologically may need to move while learning - memory overload - chronic memory problems - difficulty translating verbal directions into action - memory deficits - difficulty transferring what is learned in class to a homework assignment - difficulty understanding the abstract concept of time - need for assistance to organize - difficulty interpreting social cues from peers - lack of knowledge of what to do - hyper or hypo sensitivity to touch - difficulty understanding social cues re: boundaries - difficulty understanding concept of ownership over time and space - immature thinking ("finders keepers") - problems with memory and/or sequencing - difficulty accurately recalling events - attempt to please by telling you what you presumably want to hear - confabulation (creating false memories - see dissociation)

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Discussion Questions

- What do you think would be a healthy way to respond to someone who has a different opinion, value or belief than you?
- Do you think it is important to respect other beliefs and opinions? Why or why not?
- How can you respect other people's beliefs and opinions?
- How do they affect the way you live your life and do your job?

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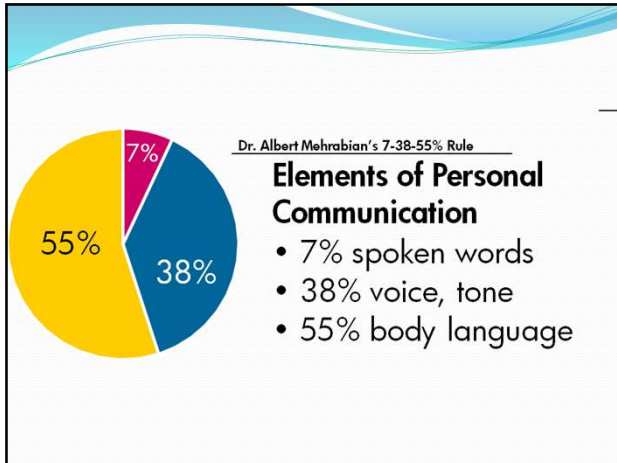
Communication

Verbal

Nonverbal



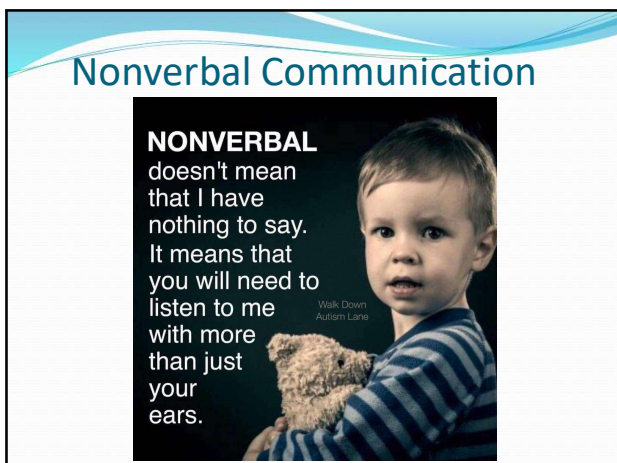
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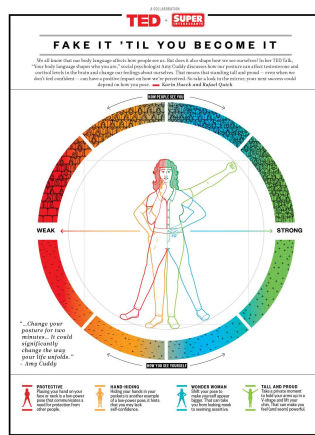
Nonverbal Communication



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Body Language and Power Posing

<https://blog.ted.com/fake-it-til-you-become-it-amy-cuddys-power-poses-visualized/>



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Closed Body Language	Open Body Language
Crossed arms or legs	Uncrossed arms and legs
Body turns away from the person	Body faces the person
Body leans back	Body leans forward
Head faces away from the person as the eyes look at the ground or stagnate elsewhere	Head faces the person as the eyes either look at the person or surroundings
Eyes are tense	Eyes are relaxed
Lowered eyebrows	Raised eyebrows
Frowns	Smile
Mouth is closed	Mouth is slightly opened
Muscles are tense	Muscles are relaxed
Tight clothing	Loose clothing
Expressionless face	Expressive face

Sample from Big Talk available at www.towersofpower.com.au/bigtalk

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Body Language

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ks-_Mh1QhMc



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Nonverbal Communication

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dP4-mmviwgg>

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Body Language

Discussion

What are the implications of body language when working with:

- Students
- Colleagues
- Parents

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Verbal Communication

Verbal Communication
Words are used to exchange information, this can be in person or by telephone and can be written or oral

Written ➤ Reports ➤ Memos ➤ Emails ➤ Fax ➤ Illustrations	Types of oral ➤ Face to face ➤ Telephone conversation ➤ Dictating letters ➤ Group discussions ➤ Meetings ➤ Speech
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Written Communication
Oral Communication

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Verbal Communication

Problems that may arise:

- Cultural barriers
- Assumptions
 - Assuming the other person thinks and listens like you do
- Confused messages
 - Blowing things out of proportion
- Relying solely on emails and texts

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Verbal Communication

Discussion:

- 1 – Do you overwhelm your people with words?
- 2 – Do you tell them only what interests you?
- 3 – Do you ignore the communication markers?
 - Communications markers are the non-verbal cues that your listener gives you. In face-to-face situations it's primarily body language and tone of voice.
- 4 – Do you assume they have understood you?
- 5 – Do you assume that it is the listener's responsibility to understand?

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Listening - Activity

Listening Questionnaire

When listening to another person, I...	Always (1 pt.)	Usually (2 pts.)	Often (3 pts.)	Rarely (4 pts.)	Never (5 pts.)
Get distracted					
Listen only to facts					
Interrupt					
Assume the other person already knows					
Prejudge					
Tune out					
Ignore nonverbal clues					
Total	+	+	+	+	+

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Listening

Listening Questionnaire Scoring

- 31–35 points = Effective Listener
- 21–30 points = Good Listener
- 14–20 points = Not-so-good Listener
- 13 points or less = Huh?

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10 Ways to have a Better Conversation

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R1vskiVDwl4>

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Verbal Communication

10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation

Celeste Headlee:

1. Don't multi-task
2. Don't pontificate
3. Use opened questions
4. Go with the flow
5. If you don't know – say so

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Verbal Communication

10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation

Celeste Headlee:

6. Don't equate your experience with another
7. Don't repeat yourself
8. Stay out of the weeds
9. LISTEN
10. Be brief

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Discussion

- How does listening impact relationships in your role as an EA – colleagues, students, parents?
- Does the person you are talking to have *the experience* of being heard? How does body language factor into that? What is the impact of listening on your interactions with colleagues
- What interferes with your listening?

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Listening Activity

1. Find a partner – choose someone you do not know well
2. Choose an A and a B
3. Think of a passion or topic of interest
4. Wait for instructions

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Possible topics for Conversations

- | | |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| • Perfect weekend | • Most relaxing vacation |
| • Most interesting <i>book</i> | • Most useless talent |
| • Best meal ever | • Bucket list |
| • Most embarrassing moment | • Social Media |
| • Greatest accomplishment | • Favourite cultural event |
| • Public Speaking | • Best date |
| • Tattoos | • Volunteering |
| • Best Pet | • Best <i>Birthday</i> gift |
| • Strangest dream | • Worst fear |
| • Pet peeve | • Favourite childhood <i>movie</i> |
| | • Most memorable teacher |

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Listening Activity 1

- Partner A will choose a random topic and then speak for one minute on how they feel about it. As they talk, partner B cannot speak – their goal is to listen.
- After one minutes, partner B has 30 seconds to recap on what partner A has said. They cannot debate, agree or disagree – only summarize.

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Listening Activity 2

1. Partner A discusses a hobby or passion of theirs, while Partner B is instructed **to ignore** them. After 1 minute SWITCH

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The Big Bang Theory- Active Listening

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gNegwrSZSNw>

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Communication and Learning Styles

- Learning Styles
- Executive Functions
- Fixed vs Growth Mindset
- Personality Types
- Communication Styles

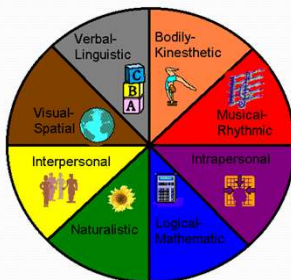
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Learning Styles



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Learning Style



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Learning Styles

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Learning Style

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Learning Style

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Learning Style

- On your own complete 02 Handout Learning Style Inventory
- Circle the letter before the statement that best describes you. Pages 1 and 2
- Add the number of responses for each letter and enter on the bottom of page 2. The area with the highest number of responses is your primary mode of learning.
- Pages 3 and 4 contain Learning Style Study Strategies - valuable in your role as an EA

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Learning Style

Discussion

What have you discovered about your own learning style and how this will impact how you might work effectively with colleagues and students?

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Executive Functions – Skills for Life

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FZLXggsK6oA>

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Executive Function

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LIT73VpSEUA>

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Executive Functions

- On Your own, complete the 03 Handout - Executive Skills Questionnaire pages 25 and 26
 - Each group of three questions corresponds with an Executive skill
 - put your three highest scores in the strongest skills column and your three lowest scores in the weakest skills column (bottom of page 26)
 - Page 27 has a description of each of the Executive skills
 - Pages 29 – 33 contain Environmental Modifications and Teaching Strategies for Specific Executive Skills (valuable for you in your role as an EA)

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Emotional Intelligence

Do you have high emotional intelligence?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nUk-_hslmWQ

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Fixed vs. Growth Mindset		
FIXED MINDSET		GROWTH MINDSET
- You have it or don't - Fixed	SKILLS	- Gained from Hard Work - Can Always Improve
- Something to avoid - Reveals lack of skill - Gives up easily	CHALLENGE	- Should be Embraced - An Opportunity to Grow - Remains Persistent
- Thinks Unnecessary - Only needed if you're not good enough	EFFORT	- Essential - A Path to Mastery
- Gets Defensive - Takes it Personal	FEEDBACK	- Useful - Learns from it - Identify areas to improve
- Blames Others - Gets Discouraged	SETBACKS	- Used as a Sign to work Harder Next Time.

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Fixed vs. Growth Mindset

Having a growth mindset means that we can change our thinking, our attitude and our actions; our personal qualities and abilities are not fixed.

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Fixed vs. Growth Mindset

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r7tjWrBey88>

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Effects of Mindsets on Learning

	Effects of the Mindsets on Learning	
	Growth Mindset <i>Desire to LEARN and GROW</i>	Fixed Mindset <i>Desire to look smart/ Avoid looking 'stupid'</i>
Challenges	Embrace Challenge	Avoid Challenge
Mistakes	Persist in the face of mistakes	Make excuses/ Give up Easily/ See as end of the road
Effort	Effort = Essential	Effort = Only for 'ungifted'/'fruitless'
Constructive Feedback	Learn from feedback	Ignore feedback
Success of Others	Find lessons and Inspiration	Feel Threatened

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Mindset

Discussion

1. When were you aware of having a fixed mindset?
2. What conditions could have changed your mindset from fixed to growth?
3. How might this information affect the way you interact with colleagues, students and parents?

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Fixed vs. Growth Mindset



I want a growth mindset, do you? ~ 🐼

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Myers Briggs Explained

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=M4YLO-2Tb2w>

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Personality Styles

1. How did the video help you understand reoccurring conflicts in different areas of your life?
2. How would this awareness impact the way you deal with colleagues, students and their parents?

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The Four Bird Model (DOPE)

DOPE is a self-assessment tool that enables a person to identify his unique and distinctive traits that clarify their personality and innermost being. People think, act, and communicate differently based upon established behavioral patterns. Recognizing these patterns can greatly enrich one's self-understanding and acceptance.

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The Four Bird Model (DOPE)

There are four main bird types for this self assessment test:

The Dove is sympathetic, moderate, people-focused.

The Owl is technical, analytical, process-focused.

The Peacock is expressive, persuasive, recognition-focused.

The Eagle is bold, confident, results-focused.

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The Four Bird Model (DOPE)

JupenIAM



www.adaptive-growth-ventures.com

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The DOPE Test - Personal Behaviour Indicator

Read each statement quickly and put a "y" in the non-coloured column if that statement DEFINITELY applies to you, and put an "n" in the column if you disagree with the statement or if the statement isn't totally true for you. See the example for how to complete. Remember, the test will only be accurate if you're honest with yourself - so complete the test based on what you actually think and feel, not on how you think you should or want to feel or behave.

Statement	Do you agree with this statement?			
Example:				
I like people who are direct				n
I pride myself in being cautious		n		
I could be considered contented, loyal, accommodating and mild.	y			
I can sometimes be subjective in my description of things			y	
Start your DOPE test here...				
I like people who are direct and to the point				
I pride myself in being cautious				
I could be considered contented, loyal, accommodating and mild.				
I can sometimes be subjective in my description of things				

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The Dove

- People-orientated, loyal, friendly hard working and a great team player but tends to avoid change, confrontation, risk-taking and assertiveness.

What doves do well:

- A natural 'people person' and enjoy helping other people succeed.
- Good at building relationships and networking – the key to your success.
- Get fulfilment from satisfying social needs like friendship and sense of belonging.

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Wise Owl

- Logical, mathematically minded, methodical and sometimes seen as a perfectionist. You can be slow to make decisions and inflexible if rules and logic says otherwise. Not a big risk taker, but you love detail.

What owls do well

- Naturally curious and interested in gaining knowledge and becoming an expert.
- Thorough, meticulous, accurate, reliable, logical and good with details.
- Like rules, procedures and structure and are a careful (but cautious) planner

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The Peacock

- Loves talking, being the centre of attention, has passion/ enthusiasm and is happy/ optimistic. They can be accused of talking too much, and aren't good with detail or time-control.

What peacocks do well:

- Enthusiastic, influential, optimistic, passionate, people-orientated, charismatic.
- Continually seek new opportunities and experiences following your passions.
- Enjoy the journey as much as the result

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The Eagle

- Dominant, stimulated by challenge, decisive and direct. They can be blunt/ stubborn, can lose sight of the big-picture and can be insensitive to other people's needs, but are natural achievers.
- What eagles do well:
- Highly focused, driven and motivated
- Result focused goal setting is 'natural' to you.
- Not afraid of failure and just see it as a challenge to bounce back.

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DOPE Model

Pass the Feather

- There is no right or wrong style – simply meant to help you discover your preference.
- DOPE Model – Do you agree with your assessment? Why or why not?

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Communication Styles

Behaviour traits influence different communication styles.

 An illustration of four people (two men and two women) sitting in a circle. Above them are four speech bubbles with labels: 'PASSIVE' (above a woman), 'PASSIVE-AGGRESSIVE' (above a man), 'AGGRESSIVE' (above a man), and 'ASSERTIVE' (above a woman).

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Communication Styles

The communication styles that most people habitually use are:

Passive
Aggressive
Passive-aggressive
Assertive

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Passive Communicators

Difficulty making eye contact
Inability to say no
Go with the flow type attitude
Poor posture

You may recognize passive communication through phrases like:

"It doesn't matter that much."
"I just want everyone to get along."

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Aggressive Communicator

You can recognize an aggressive communicator with the following behaviors:

Talks over other people
Poor listening, interrupts frequently
Controlling or demanding
Points fingers
Stares and glares intensely
Frowns
Criticizes, intimidates, or threatens others

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Aggressive Communicator

You may recognize aggressive communication through phrases like:

"This is all your fault!"

"I'm right, and you're wrong."

"Because I said so."

"You are such a loser!"

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Passive-Aggressive Communicator

Passive-aggressive communication seems passive on the surface but reveals a hidden resentment that comes through in subtle, indirect ways.

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Passive-Aggressive Communicator

You can recognize passive-aggressive communication with the following behaviors:

Frequent sarcasm

Words don't align with actions

Facial expressions don't match words

Difficulty acknowledging emotions

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Passive-Aggressive Communicator

You may recognize passive-aggressive communication through phrases like:

"That's a great car, it's almost as nice as John's."

"I wish you would clean up the house, but I know you're busy and that's not going to happen."

After saying something rude, sarcastic, or damaging, "I was only joking."

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Assertive Communicator

The assertive style of communication offers an effective and healthy way to express yourself. It encourages open, honest dialogue while still considering the needs of others.

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Assertive Communicator

You can recognize assertive communication with the following behaviors:

The ability to express desires and needs with confidence

Encourages balanced conversations in which both people have a chance to speak

The use of "I" statements (ex: I feel frustrated when people show up late.)

The ability to say no

Maintains good eye contact

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Assertive Communicator

You may recognize assertive communication through phrases like:

"Thanks for thinking of me, but I'm going to say no this time."

"I feel upset and uncomfortable that I can't access my parking space."

"I respect your opinion, but let's agree to disagree."

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Communication Styles

Communication styles are fluid. You may rely on an aggressive approach with family members but speak more passively with work colleagues. Communication styles also shift and change over time as we grow and learn from life experiences.

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Communication Styles

Try these conversational techniques to communicate more assertively:

1. Direct eye contact
2. Assertive stance or posture
3. Tone of voice
4. Facial expression
5. Timing
6. Nonthreatening, non-blaming language
7. Clarity
8. Positive language without criticism

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The DISC Model



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The DiSC Model

- Complete 06 Handout DiSC Assessment.
- Circle the one word in each row that you feel best describes you right now page 1.
- Transfer your answers to the scoring sheet page 2.
- Look at 07 Handout DiSC Dimensions for a description of all four DiSC dimensions and the strengths and stretches associated with them.
- Look at the strengths and stretches of the areas you scored highest in?
- How will this impact you as you work as an EA?

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Communication and Personality Styles

Discussion

- Did you agree or disagree with your assessment?
- How was it similar / different than the DOPE assessment?
- How can the results from these two assessments help you in your role as an Education Assistant?
- Where do you need to stretch yourself in order to meet the challenges of your role as an EA?

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Unit 1 - Review

- Personal Beliefs and Biases
- Verbal and Non-verbal Communication
- Communication Styles
- Learning and Personality Styles
- Executive Functions
- Fixed Vs Growth Mindset
